Chapter Thirty-Five

From Bouvines to Magna Carta

Between 1213 and 1217, John of England fails to regain his French lands, forfeits control of England, and loses his life

At the beginning of 1213, Innocent III decided that the interdict on England was clearly not going to resolve the quarrel over Stephen Langton's appointment as Archbishop of Canterbury.

Once again, he reached for his weapon.

"Being deeply grieved," writes Roger of Wendover, "he decreed that John king of England should be deposed from the throne of that kingdom." And then he went one step further.

> [He] wrote to the most potent Philip, king of the French, ordering him, in remission of all his faults, to undertake this business, and declaring that, after he had expelled the English king . . . he and his successors should hold possession of the kingdom of England for ever. Besides this, he wrote to all the noble knights, and other warlike men throughout the different countries, ordering them to assume the sign of the cross and to follow the king of the French as their leader, to dethrone the English king, and thus to revenge the insult which had been cast on the universal